

Technical Assessment Rubric

Score practical exercises against explicit anchors — and know when a take-home is fair and when it is an imposition.

Purpose

A technical assessment shows you how a candidate actually works, not just how they talk about working. This rubric gives you explicit scoring criteria and anchors so a practical exercise is marked consistently by anyone on the panel — and it sets out when a take-home task is a reasonable ask and when it disrespects a candidate's time.

When to use it

- For any role where hands-on ability is central and you want evidence beyond conversation.
- When more than one assessor marks the same exercise and you need them calibrated.
- To make a practical stage defensible and fair rather than a matter of taste.

Is a take-home reasonable here? (decide before you set one)

Reasonable	Unreasonable
Timeboxed to roughly 1-2 hours, and you say so honestly.	Open-ended "spend as long as you like" tasks that reward whoever has the most free time.
Directly relevant to the job (e.g. review a small test suite, design tests for a spec).	Building real product features you could ship — that is unpaid work, never acceptable.
Assessed against a shared rubric, feedback offered.	Marked on a marker's whim with no criteria.
Flexible timing and a live-exercise alternative for those with caring duties or a day job.	A rigid weekend deadline that quietly excludes carers and the already-employed.
Offered with a paid option for anything substantial.	Hours of unpaid effort with no reciprocity or feedback.

When in doubt, prefer a short live exercise or a pairing session over a large take-home. A 45-minute paired problem often reveals more than a polished solo submission, and it respects everyone's time equally.

Instructions

1. Choose an exercise that mirrors the real job — for an automation role, reviewing and improving a flaky test beats writing an algorithm.
2. Give every candidate the same brief, the same time and the same rubric.
3. Score each criterion 0–4 against the anchors; write a one-line justification per criterion.
4. Assess reasoning and approach, not just whether the output "works" — how they got there is the point.
5. Offer brief feedback to every candidate; it is common courtesy and protects your employer brand.

Scoring anchors (0–4)

Score	Meaning
0	Absent or fundamentally flawed.
1	Attempted but weak; misses the point of the exercise.
2	Competent; does the obvious thing correctly.
3	Strong; thoughtful, handles edge cases, explains trade-offs.
4	Exceptional; the approach teaches the panel something.

Worked example

Candidate A's assessment. The exercise: a 90-minute paired session reviewing a small extract of Northstar's flaky Selenium suite and proposing how to stabilise it.

Criterion	Score	Justification
Problem diagnosis	4	Immediately separated flakiness causes (timing, shared test data, environment) rather than treating them as one problem.
Test design & coverage judgement	3	Questioned whether all the tests earned their place; proposed deleting low-value ones — unusual and welcome.
Code / automation quality	3	Clean, readable fixes; sensible use of explicit waits over sleeps.
Trade-off reasoning	3	Weighed stabilise-versus-rewrite and justified stabilising first.
Communication during the exercise	2	Solid but occasionally lost the non-specialist observer in detail.
Total (max 20)	15	Strong technical showing; communication is the development edge.

Read: exactly the diagnostic, value-driven automation thinking the role needs, with a known and coachable gap on communicating to a mixed audience.

HR AND LEGAL NOTE

This is a decision-support tool, not legal advice. Always run your process through your own HR/People team and follow local employment law on data handling, right-to-work, records retention, reasonable adjustments and non-discrimination. Ask every candidate for a role the same questions against the same criteria, record the evidence rather than the impression, and keep your notes factual — they may be disclosable.

How to interpret the results

- A high total with a 0 or 1 on a make-or-break criterion is not a pass — read the criteria, not just the sum.

- Reward good process on an incomplete solution over a complete solution reached by luck. In testing, how you reason is the skill.
- Compare each candidate against the rubric, never against the strongest submission — otherwise your bar drifts with the field.
- Use the technical score alongside the behavioural scorecard; a brilliant technician who cannot collaborate may still be the wrong hire for a team that needs shared ownership.

Blank reusable version

Criterion	Score (0-4)	Justification
Problem diagnosis		
Test design & coverage judgement		
Code / automation quality		
Trade-off reasoning		
Communication		
Total		

Common mistakes

COMMON MISTAKES

Take-homes disguised as free labour — building something you could actually ship. Open-ended tasks that reward free time over talent and quietly exclude carers and the employed. Marking on personal taste with no anchors. Judging only whether the output works, ignoring the reasoning that is the real signal. Setting a puzzle unrelated to the job. Never giving feedback, which damages your reputation with every candidate who talks to peers.

INSIDE STLC PRO TIP

A 45-minute paired exercise usually out-predicts a polished take-home and treats every candidate’s time as equally valuable. If you find yourself designing a task that would take you a whole evening, you are no longer assessing a tester — you are asking for a favour.